Draft - expert review pending

Note: This unit is complete and passes the platform's automated checks, but it is not reviewed yet. So, treat its sources and claims with care. You are encouraged to report errors and provide feedback.

Topic 6.3 - Writing to reflect on your teaching

A real classroom situation

A supervisor reads three journal entries from the same trainee, all about lessons that "did not go well". The first entry reads:

> "The pupils did not understand the lesson. I explained again. They still did not understand. I felt frustrated."

The second reads:

> "The pupils did not understand the lesson. I think it is because I assumed they had the prerequisite knowledge, and they did not. Next week I will check their understanding before I start."

The third reads:

> "The pupils did not understand the lesson. I assumed they had the prerequisite knowledge because they passed the last test. But the last test only checked recall, not understanding. So passing it did not mean what I thought it meant. I have been using test results as a proxy for readiness, and the proxy is unreliable. I need a better way to check before I start."

Three levels of journal writing

Descriptive	Assumption	Evidence-tested
Focus What happened events and actions	What I assumed beliefs behind actions	What the evidence shows tested against data
Question What did I do? chronological account	Why did I think that? uncovering beliefs	Is my view supported? checking against facts
Depth Surface description only	Intermediate identifies assumptions	Deep challenges and refines
Outcome Record of events limited learning	Awareness of beliefs some insight	Changed understanding actionable learning

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The supervisor gives the first entry a low mark, the second a pass, the third a strong pass. The difference is not the writing quality. All three are clearly written. The difference is the *thinking*: the first recounts, the second identifies an assumption, the third tests the assumption against evidence. This topic shows you how to write the third kind.

Explanation

Descriptive writing vs reflective writing

Descriptive writing answers "what happened". Reflective writing answers "what happened, why, and what I will do about it". The difference is the same one Unit 1 drew between a claim and an argument: a claim states a position, an argument supports it with reasons. A descriptive entry states what happened. A reflective entry supports an analysis with evidence.

The first entry above is descriptive. It states what happened (pupils did not understand, I explained again) and how the writer felt (frustrated). It does not analyse *why* the pupils did not understand, and it does not propose a response with a reason. It is a diary entry.

The second entry is reflective at the assumption level. It identifies a possible cause (I assumed prerequisite knowledge they did not have) and proposes a response (check before starting). It is a passable journal entry. But the assumption has not been tested - the writer *thinks* the pupils lacked prerequisites, but does not say what evidence supports that.

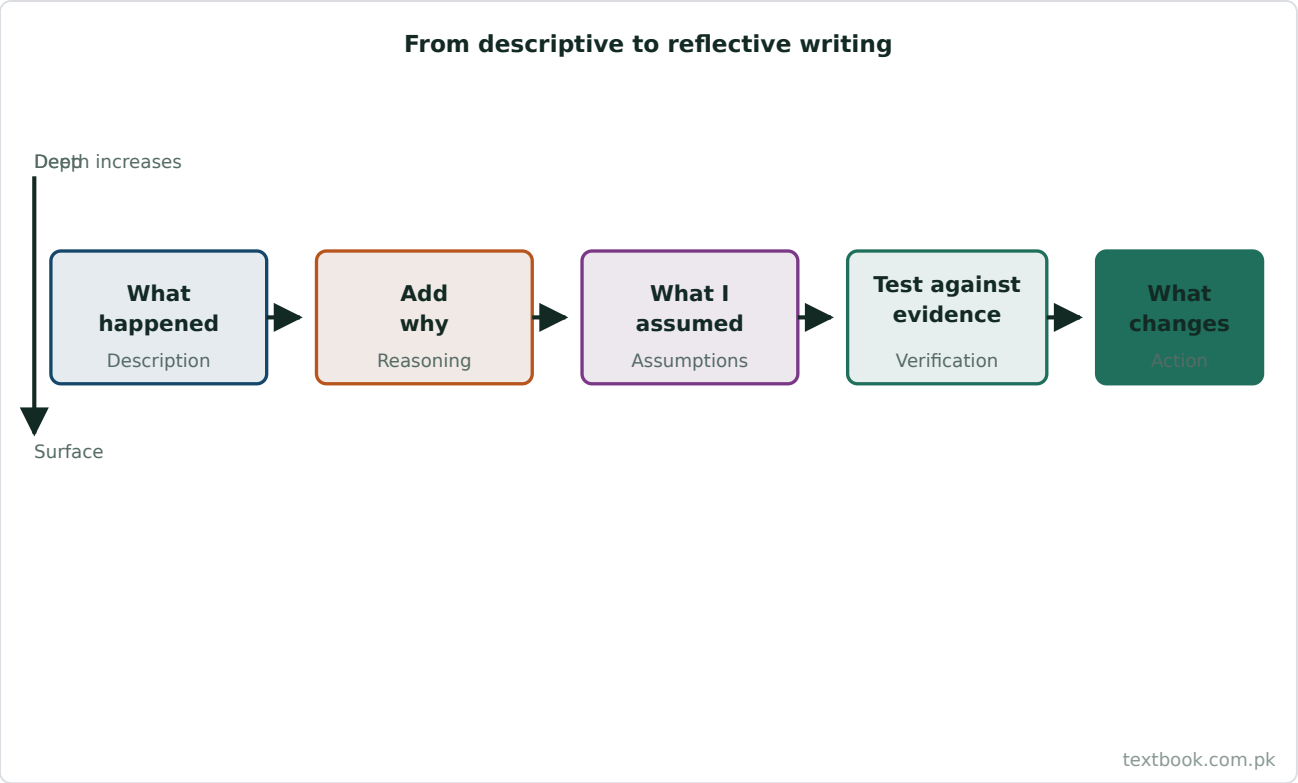
The third entry is reflective at the evidence-tested level. It identifies the assumption (they passed the last test, so they were ready), tests it against evidence (the test only checked recall), and draws a finding that changes practice (test results are an unreliable proxy, I need a better check). This is the level an assessed file should reach.

The Unit 1 standards return

The standards from Unit 1 (clarity, accuracy, relevance, depth, logic, fairness) apply to your own writing just as they apply to a staffroom argument. When you write a journal entry, test it against the same standards you would use on someone else's reasoning:

- **Clarity:** Is the entry specific enough to act on? "I will teach better" is not clear. "I will check prerequisite knowledge with three quick questions before I start" is.
- **Accuracy:** Are the claims I make about the lesson supported by evidence, or are they assumptions I have not tested?
- **Depth:** Does the entry address the cause of the problem or only the symptom? "The pupils were noisy, I will discipline them" treats the symptom. "The pupils were noisy because the task was too open" treats the cause.
- **Logic:** Does the proposed response follow from the analysis? If the analysis says the problem was unclear instructions, the response should

address instructions, not discipline.



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> **Common misconception: "the journal is for the tutor."** It is not. The journal is for you. The tutor reads it and marks it, but the learning happens when you write it, not when they read it. A journal written to impress a tutor is safe, bland and generic. A journal written to learn from your practice is honest, specific and sometimes uncomfortable. Markers reward the second and can tell the difference. Write for yourself.

A worked example before you try it

Here is the move from descriptive to reflective, performed once, on the same lesson.

> "I gave the pupils a worksheet. Half of them did not finish. I was disappointed."

Step 1 - descriptive. This is what the entry says now. It states the outcome and the feeling. It does not analyse.

Step 2 - add analysis. "Half of them did not finish. I think the worksheet had too many questions for the time, and the last three questions required a concept I had not explained."

Step 3 - test the analysis against evidence. "I gave them twenty questions in twenty minutes. The first twelve took most pupils about twelve minutes, leaving eight minutes for the last eight questions. The last three questions required the formula from the previous lesson, which I had set for homework but not checked. So the time was tight *and* the prerequisite was not secure. I assumed they had done the homework; the evidence is that they had not."

Step 4 - draw a finding. "I have been setting homework and assuming it was done without checking. The worksheet showed me that assumption was wrong. Next time I will check the prerequisite before I set the task, and I will time the worksheet myself before I give it out."

Now you try the same move in the activity.

Activity: Three levels on one incident

Work in pairs. About 25 minutes.

Take this incident:

> "I asked the class a question. Only two pupils put their hands up. I answered the question myself and moved on."

Write three entries about this incident:

- **Entry 1 - descriptive:** what happened and how you felt (no analysis).

- **Entry 2 - reflective with assumption:** what happened, what you assumed, and what you will try.
- **Entry 3 - reflective with evidence-tested assumption:** what happened, what you assumed, what evidence would support or challenge the assumption, and what changes.

Then swap with another pair. For each pair's Entry 3, say whether the evidence genuinely tests the assumption or merely restates it.

Check your understanding

1. **Remember** Name the difference between descriptive writing and reflective writing in a journal.

2. **Understand** In two or three sentences, explain why "the pupils did not understand, I will explain again" is not a reflective entry.

3. **Apply** A journal entry reads, "The group work was chaotic. Next time I will give clearer instructions." Using the three levels from this topic, name the level and say what would move it to the next level.

4. **Apply** A journal entry reads, "I assumed the pupils had done the homework. They had not." Is this Entry 2 or Entry 3? Justify in one sentence.

Summary

> Descriptive writing states what happened. Reflective writing analyses why it happened, tests the analysis against evidence, and draws a finding that changes practice. The Unit 1 standards apply to your own journal entries: clarity, accuracy, depth and logic are what separate a passing entry from a strong one. Write for yourself, not for the tutor. A journal written to learn is honest and specific; a journal written to impress is safe and generic. The marker rewards the first.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- [ ] I can distinguish descriptive writing from reflective writing and give an example of each.
- [ ] I can name the three levels of reflective writing (descriptive, assumption, evidence-tested).
- [ ] I can apply the Unit 1 standards to evaluate a journal entry.
- [ ] I can rewrite a descriptive entry so it reaches the evidence-tested level.

Try this at your practicum school

Take one entry you have already written (or write one this week). Rewrite it at the next level up. If it is descriptive, add an assumption and test it. If it is at the assumption level, test the assumption against evidence. Bring both versions to your tutorial and be ready to explain the difference.

Summative task

Here is a journal entry:

> "The test results were poor. Twelve out of thirty pupils failed. I am disappointed. I will teach the chapter again before the exam."

Write 200 to 250 words that (a) names the level of this entry and gives two pieces of evidence, (b) rewrites it at the evidence-tested level with at least one testable hypothesis and a finding, and (c) applies two of the Unit 1 standards to the original entry and says how each was breached.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	Levels
Level naming	0-2: correctly identifies the level with two pieces of evidence / one piece / wrong.
Rewrite at evidence-tested level	0-3: includes a testable hypothesis, evidence that would support or challenge it, and a finding that changes practice (**Analyze*: the rewrite turns on the specific content of the incident) / an assumption without testing / stays descriptive.
Standards applied	0-3: applies two Unit 1 standards to the original and explains how each was breached / applies one / none.
Clarity	0-2: within the word band and organised under the three parts / unclear or over length.

Further reading

Jasper, M. (2003). *Beginning reflective practice*. Nelson Thornes. Chapter 4 discusses the move from descriptive to reflective writing.

Brookfield, S. D. (2017). *Becoming a critically reflective teacher* (2nd ed.). Jossey-Bass. Chapter 5 applies critical standards to teachers' own reflective accounts.

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